



Running Your Buyer Surveys

A short guide for Assembly AI clients using Survey Mode

Surveys reach more people than interviews, in less time, with less effort from you. The tradeoff is depth: you get the answer, not the reasoning behind it.

Most of what determines whether your survey produces anything useful happens **before you send it**. This guide covers that, plus how to run the field period and know when you have enough.

First: should you survey or interview?

You can do both, and most clients should. But if you have to pick per group:

GROUP	USUALLY BETTER	WHY
Your own team	Survey	You control access, response rates are high, and you want breadth across sales, marketing, and leadership
Current customers	Either	Survey for volume, interview your best five for depth
Customers you lost	Interview	Lost customers almost never fill out a survey. They will often take a 30-minute call
Prospects who have not bought	Survey	You usually do not have the relationship to ask for an hour

That lost-customer row matters more than it looks. It is consistently the most valuable data in the entire process, and it is the group a survey is least likely to reach. Plan to call them, or ask us to.

Before you send

Generate a separate link for each audience and segment

This is the step people rush, and it is the one that quietly ruins the analysis.

Assembly AI creates a **unique link per audience per segment**. The link is what tells the system who answered. If you send your "current customer" link to a group of prospects, their answers get filed as customer answers, and the comparison that makes this whole process work is now wrong. There is no way to untangle it afterward.

Generate one link per group. Label them clearly before you start sending.

Keep it to 15 to 20 questions per audience

Below 15 and you will not cover all seven stages of the buying decision. Above 20 and completion rates fall off sharply. Survey Builder shows you a live count.

Do not soften the questions

The instinct is to reword anything that feels blunt or uncomfortable. Resist it.

Questions like "what almost stopped you from buying" feel awkward to send. They are also the ones that produce the answers worth having. A softened question produces a softened answer, and softened answers cannot be turned into positioning.

Getting responses

Start from the right assumption

Most people send these invitations bracing for annoyance. That is almost always the wrong read.

Being asked for your opinion is flattering. Customers, prospects, and even the ones who chose someone else are generally glad to be asked what they think, and many are genuinely interested in the answer you end up with. The resistance you run into is rarely "I do not want to." It is "I do not have twenty minutes right now."

That distinction should shape everything about how you ask. **You are not overcoming reluctance. You are competing for time.** So make the time cost small, make it explicit, and make it easy to say yes to.

The invitation matters more than the survey. A good survey with a bad invitation gets 4% response. The same survey with a good invitation gets 40%.

Who sends it

The person with the actual relationship. Not `noreply@`, not a marketing automation blast. If an account manager owns the relationship, the request should come from that account manager's own inbox.

What to say

Short, personal, honest about the ask, and specific about the time. Something like:

Hi Dana,

We are doing some work to understand how companies like yours actually make decisions in our category, and I would value your perspective specifically.

It is about 10 minutes, and the questions are about your buying process rather than about us. No sales follow-up, I promise.

I know your time is worth more than this, but I would like to send you a \$50 gift card as a thank you.

[link]

Thank you, it genuinely helps.

Four things make that work: it says how long, it makes clear this is not a pitch in disguise, it explains why *them*, and it removes the time objection with a small thank you.

Do not survey only the people who like you

This is the single most common way these projects fail.

The natural instinct is to send to your happiest, most engaged customers, because they will respond. They will. And they will tell you that everything is fine, because for them it is. You will finish with a clean dataset that confirms what you already believed.

Deliberately include the quiet accounts, the ones who nearly churned, and the ones you had a rough implementation with.

If you are also running interviews, the companion interview guide has a framework for choosing which current customers are worth an hour of conversation: your most profitable, most loyal, most influential, and highest growth potential. Use it for interview selection. Do not use it to build your survey list, which should be deliberately broader than your favourites.

Timing and reminders

Send Tuesday through Thursday, mid-morning in the recipient's time zone. Leave the survey open for **two weeks**. Send exactly one reminder after five to seven days, to non-responders only.

More than one reminder does not meaningfully lift response rate and does cost you goodwill.

Offer an incentive

Since the obstacle is time rather than willingness, the most effective thing you can do is compensate people for the time.

A modest gift card goes a long way. It is not a bribe and nobody treats it as one. It is an acknowledgment that you asked for twenty minutes of someone's working day, and it converts a "sure, sometime" into a completed response this week. In practice it lifts response rates more than any amount of rewriting the invitation.

Say it up front in the ask, not as a surprise afterward. The point is to remove the hesitation before it forms.

A donation to a charity of their choice is a good alternative where a gift card would be awkward, such as with public-sector buyers or companies with strict gift policies. Ask, do not assume, if you are unsure.

What your respondents will see

Before the questions, respondents can optionally provide:

- Name
- Job title
- Company and company size
- Their role in the decision, chosen from Final Decision Maker, Strong Influence, Evaluator, Champion, Gatekeeper, End User, or Observer

All of it is optional, and that is a real tradeoff.

Leaving it blank raises candor. Filling it in lets you see that your champions and your economic buyers describe the decision completely differently, which is often the most actionable finding in the whole study.

Our suggestion: in your invitation, tell people the identifying fields are optional and that role is the one you would most appreciate. Role gives you the analytical power without asking anyone to put their name to a critical comment.

How many responses do you need?

This is pattern-finding, not polling. You are not calculating a margin of error. You are looking for the point where new responses stop introducing new language.

Practical targets per audience:

RESPONSES	WHAT YOU HAVE
Under 5	Anecdotes. Not enough to act on
8 to 12	The working range. Themes become visible

RESPONSES	WHAT YOU HAVE
15+	Comfortable, and enough to compare across roles

The real signal is repetition. When the last three responses say what the first eight already said, in the same words, you have what you need. That usually arrives sooner than people expect.

Coverage beats volume. Twelve responses spread across four roles is worth far more than forty responses from people who all do the same job.

While it is running

Responses land in Response Manager automatically. Check in twice during the two weeks and watch two things:

Are all your groups filling up? If your team responded and your customers did not, you have a distribution problem, not a survey problem. Fix the ask, do not extend the deadline.

Are the open-ended answers substantive? One-word answers across the board usually mean the invitation set the wrong expectation about effort, or the survey went out to people too far from the buying decision.

Already have survey data elsewhere?

If you have run something similar in SurveyMonkey, Typeform, Google Forms, or your CRM, you do not have to redo it. Export it to CSV and use the CSV Upload tab in Response Manager. You will map your columns to our questions during the import.

Quick checklist

Before sending:

- ☐ Separate link generated for each audience and segment
- ☐ 15 to 20 questions per audience
- ☐ Questions left blunt, not softened
- ☐ Invitation written personally, from a real person
- ☐ Recipient list deliberately includes unhappy and quiet accounts
- ☐ Lost customers routed to interviews instead
- ☐ Incentive decided and stated in the invitation

While running:

- ☐ One reminder after five to seven days, non-responders only
- ☐ Open for two weeks
- ☐ Coverage checked across all groups midway

Before analyzing:

- ☐ At least 8 responses per audience
- ☐ More than one decision role represented
- ☐ New responses have stopped introducing new language

Questions

Reach out any time at **info@assemblynetworks.net**. If response rates are not where you want them, tell us early. It is almost always fixable by changing the ask, and much harder to fix after the field period closes.